

CASE STUDY

LakeShow UK 2025

A digital marketing campaign to grow the LA Lakers' UK fanbase

Module	SSP6109 — Digital Sports Marketing
University	Cardiff Metropolitan University
Deliverables	Full campaign strategy · TikTok video · Instagram carousel · Live website
Skills shown	Digital strategy · Audience research · Content creation · SEO · KPI design · Campaign planning

The brief

Design and deliver a complete digital marketing campaign for the Los Angeles Lakers in the UK market, targeting male fans aged 18–24. The campaign had to span multiple platforms, include real creative artefacts, and be built around a clear strategic objective with measurable KPIs.

The campaign I created — LakeShow UK — ran across TikTok, Instagram, X, and a purpose-built fan hub at lakeshow.co.uk. Every element was designed to serve a single, data-backed objective.

The objective

Target: achieve a 20% engagement rate uplift among UK males aged 18–24 across Instagram, TikTok, and X, measured bi-weekly against a December 2024 baseline via Sprout Social. Secondary: 20,000 unique visitors to lakeshow.co.uk in January–February 2025.

Why this target? UK basketball participation has grown 26% since 2019. UGC-led campaigns in sport generate 15–30% engagement uplifts. The Lakers already hold 25.1M Instagram followers — the real gap isn't reach, it's depth of UK community engagement. The objective is designed to fix that.

The audience

I built the campaign around a single consumer persona: Calvin, a 21-year-old London student who discovered the Lakers through NBA 2K. He consumes sport on TikTok (~90 mins/day) and Instagram (~60 mins/day), and intersects basketball with streetwear, UK grime, and gaming culture. The campaign needed to feel native to his world — not like a brand talking at him.

TikTok

Instagram

26%

6.9×

90 mins/day	60 mins/day	UK basketball growth since 2019	UGC vs branded content authenticity
-------------	-------------	---------------------------------	-------------------------------------

What I built

Each artefact maps to a specific stage of the RACE framework (Reach–Act–Convert–Engage), so the campaign works as a connected system rather than isolated pieces.

Platform	RACE stage	What it does
TikTok 30-sec video	Reach	10-10-10 structure: 0–10s cold-audience hook (silence + UK location signal), 10–20s UK grime over rapid highlight reel, 20–30s Lakers jersey reveal and lakeshow.co.uk CTA. Engineered for TikTok's For You Page completion-rate algorithm.
Instagram 6-slide carousel	Act / Engage	1080×1080px carousel posted 19:00–21:00 GMT (UK peak). Purple/gold brand palette. Montserrat Extrabold headings. Carousel format earns preferential algorithm distribution via extended session time and saves/shares weighting.
lakeshow.co.uk Live fan hub	Engage	GitHub Pages. Game time converter (GMT/BST), player profiles, weekly polls, #LakeShowUK UGC wall, quizzes. GA4-tracked. SEO-optimised. Two-click maximum from discovery to engagement. Three repeat-visit triggers keep Calvin returning week to week.

The entire user journey was engineered to a two-click maximum: platform post → lakeshow.co.uk → specific content. Every additional click reduces conversion by 10–20%.

Media strategy

The campaign uses the POEM framework (Paid, Owned, Earned) to balance spend efficiency with long-term community building. Paid activity is front-loaded January–March to capitalise on peak NBA London search demand (Google Trends: 47.9/100 during campaign window vs 10.0/100 off-season). Organic activity runs always-on for the full six months.

- Paid: Meta lookalike audience boost targeting UK males 18–24. Promoted posts on X during NBA game windows. 70% of paid budget allocated to TikTok and Instagram where Calvin's attention lives.
- Owned: lakeshow.co.uk fan hub. @Lakers Instagram and TikTok @lakers organic content. #LakeShowUK hashtag campaign seeded across all channels.
- Earned: Bronny James Instagram Live AMAs (20:00 GMT, last Thursday of month). UGC Duet/Stitch challenge targeting 500 entries/month. UK press outreach targeting BBC Sport and The Athletic.

SEO: 'Los Angeles Lakers' dominates UK searches at 47.9/100 during the campaign window. Keywords cross-embedded across all three artefacts and lakeshow.co.uk for consistent signal reinforcement.

How success is measured

KPI	Target	Measurement tool
Overall engagement rate uplift (PRIMARY)	+20% vs Dec 2024 baseline	Sprout Social — bi-weekly
Unique visitors to lakeshow.co.uk	20,000 (Jan–Feb)	GA4
#LakeShowUK UGC posts per month	500+	Sprout Social hashtag monitor
CTA click-through from landing page	≥5% of visitors	GA4 + event tracking
Fan comment/DM response time	< 2 hours	Sprout Social unified inbox

What this demonstrates

This campaign required me to think like a brand manager, a digital strategist, and a content creator simultaneously. The strategic layer — SMART objective, RACE funnel, POEM framework, SEO keyword strategy — is underpinned by genuine audience insight rather than generic planning. Calvin isn't a demographic; he's a character whose media behaviour shaped every decision in the campaign.

Building lakeshow.co.uk as a live deliverable was a deliberate choice. In a world where anyone can write a strategy document, shipping something — even a fan hub — shows you can follow through from idea to execution.

The gap in UK Lakers fandom isn't awareness — it's community. LakeShow UK is designed to fix that gap, not just fill a brief.